invites the candidate to provide a general overview. A straightforward answer (in chapter 4.1) would explain that the Virtual DOM is a lightweight, in-memory representation of the real DOM. React uses it to optimize rendering by comparing the previous and next states of the Virtual DOM and updating the real DOM only where differences exist.

- *Follow-up questions (narrowing down)*—Based on the candidate's response, the interviewer asks follow-up questions that gradually narrow the focus, seeking more specific details. For example, the interviewer might ask, "Can you walk me through the step-by-step process of how React updates the Virtual DOM and subsequently the real DOM?" In response, the candidate can elaborate on React's three-phase rendering process—render, pre-commit (reconciliation), and commit phases—as discussed in chapter 4.1, and explain how these steps enhance React's performance.
- *Probing questions (drilling deeper)*—The interviewer uses probing questions to explore particular aspects of the topic, thoroughly assessing the candidate's depth of knowledge and understanding. For instance, the discussion may focus on the React Fiber architecture, which fundamentally improves React's ability to handle complex and dynamic UIs through incremental rendering. React breaks down rendering work into smaller units called fibers, allowing it to pause and resume work as needed. By combining incremental and asynchronous rendering with prioritization and a work-in-progress tree for UI updates, the Fiber architecture enhances the performance and responsiveness of React applications. Additionally, candidates can connect this knowledge to practical development strategies, such as minimizing unnecessary rerendering by updating only the affected branches of the Virtual DOM tree. This demonstrates not only a strong conceptual understanding but also the ability to apply these concepts in real-world scenarios.

When interviewers use the funneling approach, they aim to assess the depth and breadth of the candidate's knowledge. The preparation should focus on demonstrating both. Here are some guidelines to help strike the right balance between breadth and depth in interview responses:

- *Master the fundamentals*—Ensure a solid understanding of core concepts and technologies to answer initial broad questions.